

Connecting Your WhatsApp Business Number

A step-by-step guide to setting up Meta WhatsApp Business Cloud API and connecting it to your BookingAI dashboard.

Estimated time: 30-45 minutes

What you'll need: a Facebook account, your business phone number, and access to receive an SMS/call on that number for verification.

What This Is For

To send and receive WhatsApp messages automatically through your Dusk AI dashboard (appointment confirmations, reminders, and an AI assistant that can chat with your customers), your WhatsApp Business number needs to be connected to Meta's WhatsApp Business Cloud API.

Your developer has already created the Meta app and your phone number is registered. This guide walks through exactly what you will see inside 'Step 2. Production setup' in the Meta App Dashboard - each step matches the screens in front of you.

By the end you will have 4 pieces of information to paste into the 'Connect WhatsApp' form in your Dusk AI dashboard:

- Phone Number ID
- WhatsApp Business Account ID (WABA ID)
- Permanent Access Token
- Display phone number (e.g. +91 96262 53222)

NOTE: If any of these steps feel too technical, your developer can complete all of this for you on a screen-share call. See 'Need Help?' at the end of this guide.

Step 1: Open Step 2. Production Setup

Go to developers.facebook.com/apps and open the app (your developer will give you access, or they may do this step themselves).

In the left sidebar under WhatsApp, click 'Step 2. Production setup'. You will see four sections on this page: Configure Webhooks, Register your WhatsApp phone number, Add payment method, and Test your registered number. Complete them in order from top to bottom.

NOTE: The app may still show 'App Mode: Development' at the top. You will switch it to Live in Step 6 of this guide. Do not worry about it for now.

Step 2: Configure Webhooks

This is the first section on the Production Setup page. Webhooks allow Meta to send you incoming customer messages and delivery status updates in real time.

1. In the 'Callback URL' field, enter exactly:
`https://duskai.net/api/v1/webhooks/whatsapp/verify`
2. In the 'Verify token' field, enter exactly:
`bookingai_2026_secret`
3. Click the blue 'Verify and save' button

Meta will send a test request to your server to confirm it is reachable. If verification succeeds the section will show a green checkmark.

NOTE: If verification fails, it usually means the server is not running or the URL was typed incorrectly. Double-check the URL has no extra spaces and uses https.

Step 3: Verify Your Phone Number and Subscribe Webhooks

Scroll down to the 'Register your WhatsApp phone number' section. You will see your WhatsApp Business Accounts (WABAs) and the phone numbers under each one.

3a. Note your IDs (you will need these later)

Each WABA shows a 'WhatsApp Business Account ID' directly under its name. Each phone number shows a 'Phone Number ID' underneath it. Write both down now.

- WABA ID example: 1037846842049930 (shown under 'slam washermenpet')
- Phone Number ID example: 1096844540188743 (shown under +91 96262 53222)

3b. Verify unverified numbers

If your number shows an orange 'unverified' badge and a 'Verify' button, click 'Verify'. You will receive an OTP via SMS or call on that number - enter it to complete verification. Numbers showing 'Registered' in green are already done.

NOTE: If the number is still active on the WhatsApp or WhatsApp Business app on a phone, verification will fail. Delete the WhatsApp account on that phone first via WhatsApp Settings > Account > Delete my account, wait a few minutes, then click Verify again. After deletion, that phone can no longer use WhatsApp.

3c. Turn on Subscribe webhooks

Next to each WABA name you will see a 'Subscribe webhooks' toggle. Turn this ON for the WABA that contains your business phone number. This connects incoming messages to your webhook URL from Step 2.

Step 4: Generate a Permanent Access Token

Scroll down to the 'Test your registered number' section. Inside it you will see 'Step 1: Generate permanent token' with a button.

1. Click the blue 'Generate permanent token' button
2. A token will appear in the field next to the button - copy it immediately and save it somewhere safe (a notes app or password manager)

NOTE: This token is shown only once. If you close the page without copying it you will need to generate a new one. Treat it like a password - never share it publicly or send it over email.

Having trouble? If the button does not work, click the 'these steps' link at the bottom of the section. This opens the older System Users path where you create an Admin system user, add assets, and generate a never-expiring token manually. Your developer can guide you through this if needed.

Step 5: Add a Payment Method

Scroll back up to the 'Add payment to send business-initiated messages' section on the same Production Setup page. You will see your WABAs listed with an 'Add payment method' button next to each.

1. Click 'Add payment method' next to your WABA
2. Add a credit or debit card and save

Meta charges a small fee per outbound message - reminders, follow-ups, and lead outreach sent before a customer messages you first. For India this is typically less than one rupee per message.

NOTE: Replies sent within 24 hours of a customer messaging you are free (service messages). Only messages your business sends first carry a fee. You get 1,000 free service conversations per month.

Step 6: Add a Privacy Policy and Switch to Live Mode

Meta requires a published privacy policy URL before your app can send messages to real customers. Your developer will provide this URL.

1. In the Meta App Dashboard, go to 'App settings' > 'Basic' in the left sidebar
2. Find the 'Privacy Policy URL' field and paste your privacy policy web address
3. Scroll down and click 'Save changes'
4. At the very top of the App Dashboard, find the toggle that says 'App Mode: Development' and switch it to 'Live'

NOTE: Until the app is in Live mode, messages can only be sent to a small list of manually approved test numbers. Switch to Live before testing with real customers.

Step 7: Enter Your Credentials in the Dusk AI Dashboard

You now have all the required information. Go to your Dusk AI dashboard (<https://duskai.net>):

1. Navigate to Dashboard > Locations
2. Find the location you want to connect and click 'Connect WhatsApp'
3. Phone Number ID: paste the ID you noted in Step 3 (e.g. 1096844540188743 for +91 96262 53222)
4. WABA ID: paste the WhatsApp Business Account ID from Step 3 (e.g. 1037846842049930)
5. Access Token: paste the permanent token you generated in Step 4
6. Display phone: enter your number in international format, e.g. +91 96262 53222
7. Click 'Connect WhatsApp'

The location now shows as 'Connected'. Test it by sending a WhatsApp message from a personal phone to your business number - you should get an AI reply within a few seconds.

Step 8: Complete Business Verification (Important)

In the Meta App Dashboard left sidebar under WhatsApp, click 'Step 3. Business verification'. This proves to Meta that your business is a real, legally registered entity and directly controls how many customers you can message per day.

Every new WhatsApp account starts with a limit of around 250 conversations per day. Completing Business Verification increases this limit significantly. Skip it now and you may hit a wall mid-day where no more messages go out.

1. Click 'Get started' at the bottom of the Production Setup page, or click 'Step 3. Business verification' in the left sidebar
2. Enter your legal business name and registered address exactly as they appear on your official documents - even small mismatches cause rejection
3. Upload one supporting document. Accepted in India:
 - GST Registration Certificate (most commonly accepted and fastest)
 - Udyam / MSME Registration Certificate
 - Certificate of Incorporation
 - Recent utility bill or bank statement showing your business name and address
4. Submit and wait. This usually takes a few hours to a few days.

NOTE: Start this as early as possible, ideally the same day you go live. Do not wait until you have already hit a messaging limit.

Step 9: Get Your Display Name Approved

The name customers see on WhatsApp when you message them goes through its own separate review. It is not automatic.

1. Go to business.facebook.com > WhatsApp Manager
2. Click on your phone number, then go to 'Profile'
3. Set your display name to your real business name as customers know it
4. Click 'Submit for review' - this usually takes 24 to 48 hours

NOTE: Until this is approved, customers may see a generic label or your raw phone number when you message them. Submit this on the same day you go live.

About Message Templates

Any message your business sends FIRST - before a customer has messaged you - must use a pre-approved message template. This covers appointment reminders, membership renewal follow-ups, and any outreach to new leads. Once a customer replies to you, your AI assistant can chat freely for 24 hours without any template.

Two categories you need to know

- Utility - factual, transactional messages only. Appointment confirmations and reminders to people who already booked belong here. No offers, discounts, or persuasive phrases allowed - even one promotional sentence gets the whole template reclassified into the more expensive Marketing category.
- Marketing - any promotional content, or outreach to someone who has not booked yet (new leads, win-back messages, special offers). The lead outreach sequence falls here.

Templates are created at:

- business.facebook.com > WhatsApp Manager > Message Templates > Create Template

Tips to get approved on the first try

- Keep Utility templates factual only: name, service, date, time - nothing else
- Check spelling before submitting - errors cause rejection
- No shortened links (bit.ly etc.) - use the full URL or none at all
- Number variables in order: {{1}}, {{2}}, {{3}} - no gaps
- Do not label a promotional message as Utility - Meta catches this

Your developer can prepare all template wording in English, Hindi, and Tamil and submit them for you. This is usually faster than doing it yourself the first time since the exact wording must match what the system sends.

Keeping Your WhatsApp Number in Good Standing

Meta continuously scores every business number. A poor score can reduce your daily messaging limit or restrict the number entirely.

- Quality rating (High / Medium / Low) - visible in WhatsApp Manager. Goes down when customers block you or mark your messages as spam.
- The system automatically stops messaging anyone the moment they reply STOP, 'not interested', or similar - the most important protection against score drops.
- Do not send messages to the same leads repeatedly beyond the built-in sequence.

NOTE: If your rating drops to Low for a sustained period, Meta can reduce your limit even if you completed Business Verification. Address opt-outs quickly.

Need Help?

If any step is unclear or you run into an error message, your developer can complete this entire setup remotely on a screen-share call. You just need to be present to receive the OTP on your business phone number.

- Complete Steps 1-7 on a screen-share call (approx. 30-45 minutes)
- Prepare and submit all message templates for approval
- Handle Business Verification if your documents are ready
- Troubleshoot any errors from Meta

Contact your developer: _____